

DESIGN BRIEF

# What Now?

*A visual redesign toward the polish, gravitas and craft of a leading law firm — translated so an anxious member of the public feels welcomed, not intimidated.*

| Field                    | Detail                                                                         |
|--------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Prepared for             | Claude Design (new visual identity + design system)                            |
| Product                  | “What Now?” — a free, login-free access-to-justice web app                     |
| Live site                | now-what-puce.vercel.app                                                       |
| Stack                    | Next.js (App Router) + Tailwind (CSS-variable token theme) + self-hosted fonts |
| Date                     | 15 August 2026                                                                 |
| Status of current design | “K2 · Deep teal & sand” — to be replaced / evolved                             |

**How to use this brief**

This document is the complete prompt. Read it top to bottom, then produce a new visual direction and design system (see “**What we need back**” near the end). Everything in “**Non-negotiable constraints**” is a hard requirement, not a preference.

**One-line kick-off you can paste:** “Redesign this access-to-justice web app to feel like the digital presence of a distinguished, trustworthy law firm — impeccable, precise and authoritative — but warm and plain enough that a stressed, non-lawyer member of the public feels in safe hands. Give me a full design direction, a token system, and mockups of the key screens (desktop + mobile). Respect every constraint in the brief.”

## 1. The ask, in one paragraph

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We have a working product with solid content and flows, but the **look and feel reads as a little childish / craft-fair** — warm, but not authoritative. We want to raise it to the standard of a **prestigious law firm**: polished, precise, considered, and unmistakably trustworthy. The catch — and the whole craft of this brief — is that our users are not corporate clients. They are ordinary people who have just been knocked back by government and are often stressed and vulnerable. So the target is not “big-law cold.” It is **the authority and craft of a top-tier firm, made genuinely human and calm.**

### What success looks like

- A stressed, non-lawyer visitor immediately feels: “this is serious, competent and on my side” — the way walking into a respected chambers feels reassuring rather than intimidating.
- Nothing on screen looks amateur, cute, or template-generic. Every detail looks deliberate.
- It still passes as calm and plain-English — never austere, never alarming, never showing off.
- The redesign maps cleanly onto our existing token-based codebase and keeps every safety and accessibility rule intact.

## 2. The product in one page

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**What Now?** is a free, login-free web app for ordinary Australians who have received an adverse government decision — a fine, a notice to vacate, a Centrelink debt, a public-housing decision. It explains the letter in plain English, finds the review pathway, lists next steps, drafts the first document, and routes the person to a real, free human service. Everything is grounded in a curated, sourced rules base; when something isn’t covered, it says so and points to help rather than guessing.

### The main journeys

1. **Work it out (“/start”) — the primary flow.** A calm 3-step guide: who made the decision → what it’s about (+ a few safety questions) → a tailored result (review options, a plain-English “ask for reasons” letter, relevant grounds, and a summary to take to a free service).
  2. **Scan or paste a letter (“/decode”).** The person photographs or pastes the letter; it is explained in the moment and never stored.
  3. **Ask a question (“/ask”).** A plain-language answer grounded in the rules, always showing where the answer came from.
  4. **Learn (“/learn”) and Common questions (“/faq”).** An editorial library explaining merits review, judicial review, the grounds of review, and answers to high-intent questions.
  5. **Get help (“/help”).** A tiered directory of free government, tribunal and community-legal services.
- A calm chat helper** (“Work it out with us”) is docked on content pages as a low-friction way in.

## 3. Who we serve — and the tension that governs every choice

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**Our users are not lawyers or corporate clients.** They are people who just got a government “no”: often stressed, in financial hardship, elderly, disabled, from a non-English-speaking background, with lower digital literacy, and very frequently on a phone. Many are anxious and worried they’ve done something wrong.

### The single most important instruction in this brief

**Deliver the polish, authority and craftsmanship of a prestigious law firm — WITHOUT the coldness, exclusivity or intimidation that big-law branding often carries.** Think of the

register of a distinguished barristers' chambers, a national law society, or a heritage civic institution that people trust: dignified, precise, quietly confident — and welcoming. If a design choice would make a frightened person feel out of place, small, or judged, it is wrong, however “premium” it looks.

#### Practical consequences of that tension

- **Authoritative, not corporate-sterile.** Gravitas through typography, restraint, whitespace and craft — not through stark black-and-white minimalism that reads as unapproachable.
- **Warm, not cute.** Warmth comes from generous type, calm neutrals and human language — never from playful icons, bright blocks, mascots or emoji.
- **Confident, not busy.** A stressed reader has little attention. One clear primary action per screen; a strong hierarchy; nothing decorative competing with the task.
- **Reassuring under stress.** The moments that carry bad news (deadlines, “we can’t confirm,” “talk to a person”) must feel calm and dignified, never like an error or an alarm.

## 4. Why we're redesigning (and an honest note on direction)

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The current look — an internal direction called “**K2 · Deep teal & sand**” — was deliberately designed to feel like “a community legal centre / good public service, **not** a law firm.” It is warm and accessible, but in practice it now reads as **under-designed and a touch childish** for the trust we're asking people to place in us. This brief is a deliberate change of direction toward prestige and authority — while keeping the accessibility and warmth that the audience genuinely needs.

### Concrete things that currently undercut the “prestige” read

- A large flat beige/sand field dominates the pages; it reads more “craft / boutique” than “institution.”
- A playful copper “?” in the wordmark and a simple “W” crest; the brand mark lacks the gravitas of a proper monogram or seal.
- Line icons sitting inside little rounded sand squares, and pill-shaped chips, give a friendly-app feel rather than a considered, editorial one.
- The overall impression is pleasant but soft — it doesn't yet convey rigour, precision, or heritage.

### You are free to start fresh

Treat the current palette, type and components (Section 7 / Appendix A) as **the baseline to replace, not to preserve**. Propose a new visual language. The only things that are fixed are the constraints in Section 6, the information architecture, and the content.

## 5. The design direction we want: “Prestige, made human”

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### Mood — the words to design against

Authoritative · precise · considered · dignified · calm · warm · trustworthy · timeless. **Not:** trendy, playful, techy, startup-y, corporate-cold, or busy.

### Reference register (the feeling, not to copy)

- A distinguished barristers' chambers or a top independent law firm's site — restraint, fine typography, generous space, quiet confidence.
- A national law society / bar association, or a well-designed courts or civic-heritage brand — institutional trust that is still public-facing.
- Premium editorial (a serious broadsheet's long-read layout) for the type and rhythm of the content pages.

### What that means concretely (guidance, not prescription)

- **Palette.** Move away from the beige-dominant field toward a more serious, layered foundation: a deep, sophisticated base (think ink / charcoal / deep navy or a deep green or oxblood used as an anchor), a refined warm off-white or bone for reading surfaces (not a flat beige), and a **single restrained accent** (a muted gold/brass or one deep jewel tone) used sparingly to signal authority. Keep it disciplined — few colours, used with intent.
- **Typography.** This is where most of the gravitas will come from. A truly excellent, authoritative serif for display (a refined old-style/transitional face, or a tasteful high-contrast one used only at large sizes), paired with a clean, confident grotesque/neo-grotesque sans for UI and long body copy. Use finely letter-spaced small-caps labels, a precise modular scale, and real typographic detailing.
- **Layout & grid.** Generous margins and whitespace, a strong column grid, exact alignment, and editorial rhythm. Let fine hairline rules and space — not boxes and shadows — do the separating. Precision reads as competence.
- **Brand mark.** Consider elevating the wordmark and mark: a dignified monogram, seal or crest motif can carry “trust” beautifully for a legal brand — executed with real craft, not a cartoon.

- **Detailing & iconography.** If icons are used at all, make them thin, precise and restrained — never cute, never in coloured bubbles. Favour typographic and rule-based devices over illustration.
- **Depth & motion.** Mostly flat and print-like; if any shadow, make it faint and expensive-looking. Motion should be minimal, smooth and purposeful — nothing bouncy or animated-for-fun.
- **Imagery.** Likely little to none. If any is used, it should be dignified and restrained (fine abstract/architectural textures, a subtle paper/letterpress quality) — never stock-photo “happy people.”

#### **Anti-patterns — please avoid**

- Anything cute: mascots, emoji, bright primary colours, rounded “friendly-app” chips, icons in coloured squares.
- Any AI/tech framing: robots, sparkles, “AI” badges, neon, gradients-as-hero, chatbot tropes.
- The generic “AI-app” look: warm-cream-plus-one-serif-plus-terracotta, a purple–blue gradient hero, Inter/Space-Grotesk as a default, everything centered, rounded-lg cards with an accent bar.
- The opposite failure: cold, sterile, exclusive “corporate law” minimalism that would intimidate a frightened person.

## 6. Non-negotiable constraints (all hard requirements)

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### 6a. Safety & content posture (this product serves vulnerable people)

- **Information, not advice.** The design must never imply we are the user's lawyer or predict an outcome. The standing disclaimer ("general information, not legal advice; we can't tell you what will happen in your case") is a permanent, visible trust surface — not hidden behind a link.
- **Deadlines are calm, never alarmist.** Time limits appear as a quiet, sourced note — never a big red countdown, never a "days left" scare. Amber/gold tones only, never red. The "we can't confirm the date" state must feel equally calm, not like an error.
- **Always offer human help.** A route to free help (community legal centres, Legal Aid, tribunals) is present in every flow and must always be easy to find.
- **Grounded-or-silent.** Where the app says "we're not sure — here's who can help," that honest state should look dignified and reassuring, not like a failure.
- **Privacy is a feature.** "We never keep your details / nothing you enter is stored" recurs as a small, quiet reassurance (a fine lock motif). Never contradict it with anything that looks like an account or tracking.
- **No AI / tech framing in any user-facing surface.** (Repeated because it's absolute.)

### 6b. Accessibility (WCAG 2.1 AA — enforced in our build)

- Every text/background pair must meet AA contrast. (Our accent and faint-ink tokens were darkened specifically to pass; any new palette must be checked the same way.)
- Mobile-first at 375px; touch targets  $\geq 48\text{px}$ ; full keyboard support with a clearly visible focus state; screen-reader friendly; respect prefers-reduced-motion.
- Plain-English reading level (~Year 6) is enforced by a linter — keep type large and comfortable; body is currently 17px. Do not go small or low-contrast for the sake of a "refined" look.
- Tolerate long strings (long agency names, translated copy) — wrap gracefully; never let the deadline, sources, help or chat controls get pushed off-screen.

### 6c. Technical (the design must be implementable in our stack)

- **Next.js (App Router) + Tailwind CSS, themed by CSS-variable tokens.** Deliver the design as a token system (colour, type, spacing, radii, shadows) that maps onto our existing Tailwind theme — not one-off hard-coded values.
- **Fonts are self-hosted via next/font (no external font CDN is allowed by our CSP).** Please choose typefaces available through Google Fonts / open licences, or flag any licensed font so we can host it.
- Keep the component architecture we already have (a shell with side rail/top-bar, shared cards, forms, a sources panel, a tiered-help block, a chat panel, guided-tour popovers). You may restyle all of them; the set of surfaces stays.
- SVG/inline icons and CSS only for decoration (our pages must stay light and fast). No heavy imagery or animation libraries.

### 6d. Brand facts to keep

- Name: "What Now?" (the question mark is part of the identity — but it can be treated with far more restraint/elegance than today).
- It is free and login-free — the design should quietly signal "free, no account" rather than "sign up."
- Australian context (Victoria + Commonwealth). A4, en-AU. Dignified and local, not flashy.

## 7. The current design system (the baseline you're replacing)

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Provided so you understand what exists and can improve on it deliberately. **This is not to be preserved.** Full token values are in Appendix A.

### In brief

- **Palette:** deep petrol teal (#10363D) rail/CTAs, warm sand background (#E8DDC7 / #F4EEDD), copper accent (#C79A52 on teal / #7A5618 on sand), a reserved deadline amber, a help green, ink text.
- **Type:** Newsreader (display serif, current), Libre Baskerville (buttons/wordmark), system sans (body). Previous iterations tried Cormorant Garamond (too thin) and Source Serif 4 (too generic) — useful history: we want authority without either flaw.
- **Shape language:** squared 4px radii, hairline rules, mostly flat. A fixed 96px vertical teal “rail” on desktop carries the wordmark; a teal top-bar on mobile.
- **Signature devices:** numbered “how it works” index; bordered “library” card grids; a persistent “Work it out with us” chat pill; a “W” crest.

## 8. Screens & surfaces to design

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Priority: **P1** = design in full (hero moments). **P2** = design via the shared system once P1 is set.

| Route                  | What it does                                                                                         | Priority |
|------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------|
| /                      | Landing / trust funnel. The first impression; one primary action (“Find out what you can do”).       | P1       |
| /start                 | The 3-step guide + tailored result. The core journey; a focused surface with its own minimal header. | P1       |
| /decode                | Scan or paste a letter → plain-English explanation + next steps.                                     | P1       |
| /ask                   | Ask a question → grounded answer with sources.                                                       | P1       |
| /learn (+ 6 sub-pages) | Editorial library: merits review, judicial review, the grounds, a comparison, a guided tour.         | P1       |
| /faq (+ article pages) | “Common questions” index + individual answer pages.                                                  | P2       |
| /help                  | Tiered directory of free government / legal / community help.                                        | P2       |
| /about, /contact       | About the service; a contact form.                                                                   | P2       |
| /privacy, /terms       | Plain-English legal pages.                                                                           | P2       |
| 404 / error            | Calm “not found” and error states that route onward.                                                 | P2       |

## 9. Components & the states that matter

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### Core components (restyle all of these)

- Site chrome: the brand mark/wordmark, the desktop rail + mobile top-bar, primary nav, footer.
- Buttons (primary / secondary / quiet text link), form inputs, checkboxes, the date field, the consent control.
- Cards: choice cards (the “who / what” options), editorial “library” index rows, content cards.
- “Where this comes from” sources panel (label + real source links).
- The calm time-limit / deadline note (and its “can’t confirm” variant).
- Tiered “Get free help” block (three tiers) and inline help callouts.
- The chat launcher (closed pill) and the open chat panel (docked desktop / full-screen mobile).
- The first-run guided-walkthrough popovers (a spotlight/coach-mark style).
- The standing disclaimer and the small privacy/lock note.

### States that must feel calm & dignified (not like errors)

- **“Talk to a person” route-out.** When a matter is sensitive (family/child-protection, criminal, detention, imminent deadline) the app stops the self-help path and hands off to a human. This should feel like being looked after, not blocked.
- **“We don’t have a guide for this yet.”** The honest not-covered state — reassuring, with a clear route to help.
- **“We can’t confirm the exact date.”** Calm, amber, never an error.
- **Loading / thinking.** A calm indicator — never “AI is typing.”
- Also design the ordinary states: hover, focus (visible), active, disabled, and form validation/error.

## 10. Voice & copy (so the visuals match)

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The words are calm, plain, and human: short sentences, no jargon, no alarm, never judgemental. The design should feel like the visual equivalent of that voice — **measured and reassuring**. Labels are quiet and precise; headlines are confident but never shouty. (You don’t need to rewrite copy; just design so it can breathe.)

## 11. What we need back

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6. **A design direction / mood.** The concept in a sentence, plus the palette, type pairing and one or two “signature” devices that carry the brand.
7. **A full token system.** Colour (with AA contrast noted for each text/bg pair), a type scale (families, weights, sizes, line-heights, tracking), spacing, radii, borders and shadows — named so we can drop them into our Tailwind theme.
8. **Key screen mockups, desktop + mobile (375px).** At minimum: the landing page, a /start step and the result, /decode, an /ask answer, and a /learn or /faq page.
9. **Component specs with states.** Buttons, forms, cards, nav, the sources panel, the deadline note (calm + can’t-confirm), the help block, the chat launcher + panel, the tour popover — each with hover/focus/active/disabled/error.
10. **Accessibility notes.** Contrast pairs, focus treatment, minimum sizes, reduced-motion behaviour.
11. **A brand mark.** An elevated wordmark and mark/monogram treatment.

A single downloadable spec (or an artifact) we can hand straight to implementation is ideal.



## 12. Keep vs change

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| Keep (do not touch)                                                                      | Change (your remit)                                       |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|
| The information architecture, routes and flows                                           | The entire visual language: palette, type, shape, texture |
| All content and copy (and its plain-English voice)                                       | The brand mark, wordmark and any crest/seal               |
| Every safety pattern (calm deadlines, always-offer-help, grounded-or-silent, disclaimer) | Layout, grid, spacing rhythm and hierarchy                |
| Accessibility rules (AA, 48px, keyboard, reduced-motion)                                 | Components, cards, buttons, forms — restyle freely        |
| The token-based, Tailwind/Next.js implementation model                                   | Iconography, motifs, depth and (minimal) motion           |

## 13. Definition of done

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- A frightened, non-lawyer visitor on a phone feels they've reached a serious, trustworthy institution that is on their side — reassured, not intimidated.
- Every screen looks deliberately designed and genuinely premium; nothing reads as childish, cute, template-generic, or cold.
- It still feels calm, plain and human, and passes every accessibility and safety rule unchanged.
- The output is a token system + mockups + component specs we can implement directly in the existing codebase.

## Appendix A — Current token reference (to replace)

### Colour

| Token                     | Hex               | Role today                                     |
|---------------------------|-------------------|------------------------------------------------|
| rail / teal               | #10363D           | Rail, primary CTA fill, help band, chat header |
| rail.dark                 | #0C2A30           | CTA hover                                      |
| rail.fg                   | #EEF0E8           | Cream type on teal                             |
| rail.accent (copper)      | #C79A52           | Brand accent, ONLY on teal                     |
| sand                      | #E8DDC7           | Page background                                |
| sand.surface / paper.warm | #F4EEDD           | Lifted surface                                 |
| paper                     | #FFFFFF           | Inputs, chat bubbles                           |
| accent (gold on sand)     | #7A5618           | Links / labels / step numbers (AA on sand)     |
| ink                       | #1C2A2B           | Headings + primary text                        |
| ink.soft                  | #566163           | Secondary text                                 |
| ink.faint                 | #586466           | Meta text ( $\geq 14\text{px}$ )               |
| gold (the deadline)       | #8A5A14           | Reserved for the deadline; amber, never red    |
| gold.soft / line          | #F6EDDA / #E6D5AB | Deadline card fill / border                    |
| help (green)              | #2C5544           | Tier-1 free help; handoff                      |
| line                      | #D3C6AA           | Hairline rules                                 |
| line.strong               | #1C2A2B           | Anchoring ink rule                             |
| danger                    | #9B2C2C           | Errors only (sparingly)                        |

### Type, radii, spacing, shadow (current)

- **Display (headings, wordmark):** Newsreader — `var(--font-display)`. Scale: H1 52px, h1 36px, h2 28px, title 22px.
- **Buttons / wordmark fallback:** Libre Baskerville — `var(--font-serif)`, 700, tracked.
- **Body / UI:** system sans — `var(--font-sans)`; body 17px / 1.62; small 15px; meta 14px; kicker 11px uppercase, tracking 0.28em.
- **Radii:** 4px (buttons, cards, inputs), 6px (panels), 9999px (pills). Deliberately squared.
- **Layout:** content max-width 1040px; 96px desktop rail; 48px / 22px side padding.
- **Shadow:** mostly flat — hairlines separate; only the chat launcher carries a soft shadow.

## Appendix B — Deeper source material (optional to share)

If Claude Design wants more context, these can be provided. This brief already distils what matters, so they are optional.

- **Live site:** [now-what-puce.vercel.app](https://now-what-puce.vercel.app) (click through /, /start, /decode, /ask, /learn, /faq, /help to feel the current design and flows).
- **Designnew/README.md** — the current “K2 · Deep teal & sand” design spec (tokens, landing layout, chat).
- **design\_handoff\_what\_now/** — an earlier “Chambers” design handoff (tokens + hi-fi HTML references).
- **CLAUDE.md / BRDnew/PRODUCT\_REQUIREMENTS.md** — the product’s safety posture, audience and requirements, in full.

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**In one line:** *give a frightened member of the public the reassurance of walking into a distinguished, trusted law firm — impeccable and authoritative — while keeping every word plain, every path calm, and every person welcome.*